well disposed, being able to ensure the continuity of his predilections as policy by his successors.

Were his subjects even vaguely convinced that a change of such magnitude had come to pass merely because their king said so? Governments in our time equipped with excellent communication systems and far more effective methods of coercion have not managed to successfully bring about social transformation simultaneously across the regions of India, so Ashoka's claim that he had does not seem credible. Their encounter with Mauryan officials charged with new responsibilities may have prompted the recognition within the populace of a ruler with exceptional drive and ambition who at least aimed, even if he did not succeed, at moral change. This may well have been Ashoka's intention. His Buddhist emphases and the outlining of differences from what had existed 'for many hundreds of years' was a statement of intent couched in the language of achievement. Departing from his minor rock edicts, the emperor now made no allusions to the value of age-old traditions, or what he had earlier called 'porana pakiti'.

In the following year, the thirteenth after his coronation, he introduced a major innovation in the institutional structure of his administration. The moral inspection tours aiding the spread of dhamma were now supplemented by the creation of a new class of very senior officials called dharma-mahamatras. The exposition on their functions is long and detailed and reveals a proactively interventionist administrative group spread across his dominions. Dharma-mahamatras were engaged everywhere 'among the adherents of Dharma (to determine) whether a person is (only) inclined towards Dharma or is (fully) established in Dharma or is (merely) given to charity.'[11] And who were the people within the domain of their work? Practically everyone, it seems: the edict specifies all religious sects, people dwelling on the empire's western borders (including the Yavanas, Kambojas, Gandharas and the Rastrika-paitryanikas), the servile class, the